CHAPTER 5

Print Culture and the Modern World

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✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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🤔 Think about · Fig. 1 – Book making before the age of print

? **Think about what happened to the art of writing and illustrating by hand with the coming of printing machines.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Hand-copying of books slowly declined because printed books were cheaper and quicker to produce.
- But the art did not die at once: early printed books still had borders and pictures painted by hand, and manuscripts like the Diwan of Hafiz continued to be made for the rich.
- Calligraphers and illustrators found new work, e.g. designing type, woodcuts and decorations for printed books.

🧪 Activity · Print Comes to Europe

? **Imagine that you are Marco Polo. Write a letter from China to describe the world of print which you have seen there.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Dear friends in Venice,

China is a land of wonders. Here books are not copied by hand. Craftsmen carve the text on **woodblocks**, ink them and rub paper (which was also invented here) against them. Since only one side of the thin paper can be printed, the sheets are folded and stitched into **accordion books**.

- The emperor's government prints huge numbers of textbooks for the civil service examinations.
- Skilled carvers copy the beauty of calligraphy with great accuracy.
- Buddhist scriptures, pictures, playing cards and even **paper money** are printed.

I shall bring this knowledge home so that we too can make books quickly and cheaply.

Your friend, Marco Polo

🧪 Activity · A New Reading Public

? You are a bookseller advertising the availability of new cheap printed books. Design a poster for your shop window.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

NEW PRINTED BOOKS – CHEAP FOR ALL!

- No more costly handwritten copies: books printed on the new press.

- Popular **ballads, folk tales and almanacs**, full of pictures – enjoy them even if you cannot read; have them read aloud at the tavern!
- Bibles and prayer books, romances and histories.
- Prices from just a penny. Many copies in stock.

Visit [Shop name], Market Street – Open every day.

(Add a picture of a printing press and of people reading.)

💬 Discuss · Print and Dissent

? Write briefly why some people feared that the development of print could lead to the growth of dissenting ideas.

✔ ANSWER

- Print made books cheap and widely available, so ideas spread quickly to many people.
- Even people who **disagreed with established authorities** could now print and circulate their ideas and persuade others.
- Religious authorities and monarchs feared that if there was no control, **rebellious and irreligious thoughts** would spread and the authority of 'valuable' literature would be destroyed.

- Example: Martin Luther's printed **Ninety Five Theses** (1517) led to the Protestant Reformation; the miller **Menocchio** reinterpreted the Bible from books he read and was executed by the Inquisition.
- Erasmus also feared that printers would fill the world with 'stupid, ignorant, irreligious and seditious' books.

So the Roman Church began an **Index of Prohibited Books** from 1558.

🧪 Activity · Print Culture and the French Revolution

? Imagine that you are a cartoonist in France before the revolution. Design a cartoon as it would have appeared in a pamphlet.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Idea for the cartoon: A thin, bent peasant carries a fat noble and a priest on his back. The noble holds a wine glass and the priest a bag of tax money. The king dances at a grand ball in the background.

Caption: "Who carries the weight of France?"

Message: the monarchy and nobility enjoy pleasures while the common people pay the taxes and suffer hardships (like Fig. 11).

Discuss · Print Culture and the French Revolution

? Why do some historians think that print culture created the basis for the French Revolution?

✔ ANSWER

Historians give three arguments:

- **Ideas of Enlightenment thinkers spread:** print popularised the writings of Voltaire and Rousseau, which criticised tradition, superstition and despotism and asked for the rule of reason. Readers began to see the world with questioning, critical and rational eyes.
- **Culture of dialogue and debate:** all values, norms and institutions were re-evaluated and discussed by a public aware of the power of reason; new ideas of social revolution came into being.
- **Literature mocking royalty:** by the 1780s cartoons and caricatures showed the monarchy absorbed in pleasures while common people suffered. This circulated underground and created hostility against the monarchy.

However, print did not directly shape minds; it opened up the possibility of thinking differently.

🧪 Activity · Further Innovations

? **Look at Fig. 13 (advertisements at a railway station in England, 1874). What impact do such advertisements have on the public mind? Do you think everyone reacts to printed material in the same way?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- **Impact:** advertisements seen again and again on walls and platforms catch attention, create desire for products, shape people's tastes and choices, and spread information about events and services.
- They can also persuade people to buy things they do not really need.
- **No, people do not react in the same way.** Reaction depends on a person's age, education, income, interests and needs. Some are attracted, some ignore them, some question them. As the chapter says, people accept some ideas, reject others and interpret things in their own way.

🧪 Activity · Print and the Poor People

1 **Look at Figs. 19, 20 and 21 carefully. What comment are the artists making on the social changes taking place in society?**

✔ ANSWER

- The artists feel that **traditional family roles are being turned upside down**.
- Fig. 19: the wife dominates the husband (sits on his shoulder) and he is cruel to his mother – destruction of proper family relations.
- Fig. 20: the man plays the veena while the woman smokes a hookah – Western influence has changed the roles of men and women.
- Fig. 21 shows a European couple, suggesting that Indians are copying Western ways.

2 **What changes in society were taking place to provoke this reaction?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Women's education** spread in the late nineteenth century and women began to read and write.
- Women gained some independence and a voice; social reform movements questioned old customs.
- **Western culture and ideas** were influencing Indian middle-class families.

These changes created anxiety about the breakdown of traditional family roles.

3 **Do you agree with the artist's view?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

No. Education and equal rights for women do not destroy families; they make women confident and families stronger. Respect for elders and equality between husband and wife can go together. The artists only show the fear of change felt by conservative people.

⭐ Write in brief

1 (a) **Give reasons: Woodblock print only came to Europe after 1295.**

✔ ANSWER

- Woodblock printing was developed in **China**; Europe did not know this technology.
- In **1295 Marco Polo**, the explorer, returned to Italy from China and brought the knowledge of woodblock printing with him.
- After that Italians began producing books with woodblocks and the technology spread to other parts of Europe.

1 (b) **Give reasons: Martin Luther was in favour of print and spoke out in praise of it.**

✔ ANSWER

- In 1517 Luther wrote the **Ninety Five Theses** criticising the practices of the Roman Catholic Church.

- Thanks to print, his writings were reproduced in vast numbers and read widely; his translation of the **New Testament sold 5,000 copies in a few weeks**.
- This led to the **Protestant Reformation**. Grateful to print, he said, **'Printing is the ultimate gift of God and the greatest one.'**

1 (c) **Give reasons: The Roman Catholic Church began keeping an Index of Prohibited books from the mid-sixteenth century.**

✔ ANSWER

- Print spread many books and new **individual interpretations of faith**, even among little-educated people.
- E.g. the Italian miller **Menocchio** read books and formed his own view of God and Creation, which enraged the Church.
- Troubled by such questioning of faith and **heretical ideas**, the Church controlled publishers and booksellers and kept an **Index of Prohibited Books from 1558**.

1 (d) **Give reasons: Gandhi said the fight for Swaraj is a fight for liberty of speech, liberty of the press, and freedom of association.**

✔ ANSWER

- Gandhi saw speech, press and association as the **three powerful vehicles of expressing and cultivating public opinion**.
- The colonial government was trying to **crush** them through press laws, censorship and suppression of newspapers.
- Without these freedoms, Indians could not spread nationalist ideas or organise; so the fight for Swaraj meant first fighting for these threatened freedoms (1922).

2 (a) **Write a short note on the Gutenberg Press.**

✔ ANSWER

- Developed by **Johann Gutenberg** at Strasbourg in the 1430s; perfected by **1448**.
- He was a merchant's son who knew wine and olive presses and, as a goldsmith, how to make lead moulds.
- The **olive press** was the model for the printing press, and **moulds were used to cast metal types** for the letters of the alphabet.
- Metal types of the 26 Roman letters could be moved to compose words – the **movable type printing machine**; it could print **250 sheets on one side per hour** and remained the basic technology for 300 years.
- The first book was the **Bible**: about 180 copies in three years.

It started the print revolution in Europe.

2 (b) **Write a short note on Erasmus's idea of the printed book.**

✔ ANSWER

- **Erasmus** was a Latin scholar and Catholic reformer who criticised the excesses of Catholicism but kept away from Luther.
- He expressed **deep anxiety about printing** in *Adages* (1508).
- He felt that the huge number of books created a **glut** that was hurtful to scholarship; only a few books were worth knowing.
- Printers filled the world with 'stupid, ignorant, slanderous, scandalous, raving, irreligious and seditious' books, so that even **valuable publications lost their value**.

2 (c) **Write a short note on the Vernacular Press Act.**

✔ ANSWER

- Passed in **1878**, after the revolt of 1857, as vernacular newspapers became assertively nationalist.
- It was **modelled on the Irish Press Laws**.
- It gave the government **extensive rights to censor reports and editorials** in the vernacular press.

- The government kept regular track of vernacular newspapers in all provinces. If a report was judged **seditious**, the paper was warned; if the warning was ignored, the **press could be seized and the printing machinery confiscated**.

3 (a) **What did the spread of print culture in nineteenth century India mean to women?**

✔ ANSWER

- Women's reading increased greatly in middle-class homes; liberal families educated women at home and sent them to schools.
- Journals carried writings by women, explained why women should be educated and gave reading matter for home schooling.
- Women became writers: **Rashsundari Debi** wrote *Amar Jiban* (1876), the first full-length autobiography in Bengali; Kailashbashini Debi, **Tarabai Shinde** and **Pandita Ramabai** wrote about women's sufferings, especially widows.
- Women's journals discussed education, widowhood, widow remarriage and the national movement; Battala books reached women at home.

3 (b) **What did the spread of print culture in nineteenth century India mean to the poor?**

✔ ANSWER

- **Very cheap small books** were sold at crossroads in Madras towns, so poor people could buy them.
- **Public libraries** (from the early 20th century) expanded access to books.
- Writings on **caste discrimination** spread, e.g. Jyotiba Phule's *Gulamgiri* (1871), and later B.R. Ambedkar and Periyar.
- Workers wrote too: Kashibaba's *Chhote Aur Bade Ka Sawal* (1938); millworkers in Bombay and Bangalore set up libraries to educate themselves.

3 (c) **What did the spread of print culture in nineteenth century India mean to reformers?**

✔ ANSWER

- Print helped reformers **spread their ideas** against widow immolation, idolatry, Brahmanical priesthood etc. in the everyday language of ordinary people.
- A wider public could take part in **public debates**; e.g. Rammohun Roy published the *Sambad Kaumudi* (1821), while the orthodoxy replied with *Samachar Chandrika*.

- Muslim reformers (ulama, Deoband Seminary) printed Urdu tracts and fatwas; caste reformers like Phule wrote against injustice.

Thus print became a powerful tool for social and religious reform.

💬 Discuss

1 **Why did some people in eighteenth century Europe think that print culture would bring enlightenment and end despotism?**

✔ ANSWER

By the mid-18th century there was a common belief that books could change the world.

- Print made books cheap and available, and **literacy rose to 60–80 %** in some parts of Europe – a 'reading mania'.
- The writings of **Voltaire, Rousseau and Thomas Paine**, and ideas of scientists like Isaac Newton, reached common people and spread ideas of **science, reason and rationality**.
- These writings attacked superstition, the sacred authority of the Church and the despotic power of the state.
- Print created a culture of **debate and discussion**, where existing values and institutions were questioned.

- Novelist **Louise-Sebastien Mercier** declared, 'The printing press is the most powerful engine of progress and public opinion is the force that will sweep despotism away', and proclaimed 'Tremble, therefore, tyrants of the world!'

So people believed print would liberate society from tyranny and bring a time when reason and intellect would rule.

2 **Why did some people fear the effect of easily available printed books? Choose one example from Europe and one from India.**

✔ ANSWER

Many feared that without control over what was printed and read, **rebellious and irreligious thoughts** would spread and the authority of 'valuable' literature would be destroyed.

Europe:

- The **Roman Catholic Church** feared new interpretations of faith. Luther's printed criticism led to the Protestant Reformation, and the miller Menocchio was executed for his views. The Church began the **Index of Prohibited Books (1558)**.
- **Erasmus** also feared that swarms of 'irreligious and seditious' books would make valuable books lose their value.

India:

- **Conservative families** feared women's reading: Hindus believed a literate girl would be widowed; Muslims feared women would be corrupted by Urdu romances.
- The **colonial government** feared nationalist newspapers and passed the **Vernacular Press Act (1878)**.

Thus religious leaders, rulers and conservatives all feared the power of print.

3 **What were the effects of the spread of print culture for poor people in nineteenth century India?**

✔ ANSWER

Print opened the world of knowledge to the poor.

- **Cheap books:** very cheap small books were sold at crossroads in Madras towns for poor people going to markets.
- **Libraries:** public libraries from the early 20th century, in cities, towns and prosperous villages, expanded access to books.
- **Voice against caste: Jyotiba Phule** wrote *Gulamgiri* (1871) on the injustices of caste; later **B.R. Ambedkar** and **Periyar** wrote powerfully on caste and were read all over India.

- **Workers' writings:** Kanpur millworker **Kashibaba** wrote *Chhote Aur Bade Ka Sawal* (1938) on caste and class exploitation; Sudarshan Chakr's poems were collected in *Sacchi Kavitayan*.
- **Self-education:** by the 1930s Bangalore cotton millworkers, following Bombay workers, set up libraries to educate themselves.

Thus print helped the poor become aware, educated and able to protest against injustice.

4 **Explain how print culture assisted the growth of nationalism in India.**

✔ ANSWER

Print became a powerful weapon of the national movement.

- **Connected people:** newspapers carried news from one place to another and created **pan-Indian identities**.
- **Criticised colonial rule:** despite repressive laws, nationalist newspapers grew in all parts of India, reported colonial misrule and encouraged nationalist activities.
- **Spread new ideas:** reform debates, writings on caste, women and society, in vernacular languages, reached a wide public and made people think critically.

- **Resisted censorship:** laws like the Vernacular Press Act (1878) provoked protests; when **Tilak** wrote in his *Kesari* in sympathy with deported Punjab revolutionaries (1907), his imprisonment in 1908 caused protests all over India.
- **Visual culture:** nationalist cartoons and caricatures criticised imperial rule.
- Leaders like **Gandhi** saw liberty of the press as central to the fight for Swaraj.

Thus print spread national feeling and united Indians against British rule.

🛠️ Project

? Find out more about the changes in print technology in the last 100 years. Write about the changes, explaining why they have taken place, what their consequences have been.

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Changes:

- Early 20th century: electrically operated presses; better paper feeding, plates, automatic paper reels and colour controls (from the chapter).
- **Offset printing** became common for books and newspapers; later **photo-typesetting** replaced metal type.

- From the 1980s: **computers and desktop publishing (DTP)**, laser and inkjet printers, digital printing.
- Today: e-books, e-newspapers, print-on-demand and 3D printing.

Why: demand for faster, cheaper and colourful printing; growth of literacy, newspapers and advertising; development of electricity, electronics and computers.

Consequences:

- Printing became fast, cheap and of high quality; anyone can print at home or office.
- Huge growth of books, newspapers and advertisements; information spreads quickly.
- Fewer jobs for traditional compositors; more use of screens and less paper.

(Collect pictures and examples from your local printing press or newspaper office for your project.)

🎉 **Chapter 5 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**